

THEATRE

देवानामिदमामनन्ति मुनयः कान्तं क्रतुं चाक्षुषं
रुद्रेणेदमुमाकृतव्यतिकरे स्वाङ्गे विभक्तं द्विधा ।
त्रैगुण्योद्भवमत्र लोकचरितं नानारसं दृश्यते
नाट्यं भिन्नरुचेर्जनस्य बहुधाप्येकं समाराधनम् ॥ ४ ॥

*Devānām idam āmananti munayaḥ kāntaṁ kratuṁ chākṣuṣhaṁ
Rudreṇedam umākṛitavyatikare svāṅge vibhaktaṁ dvidhā |
Traiguṇyodbhavam atra lokacharitaṁ nānārasaṁ dṛiṣhyate
Nāṭyaṁ bhinnarucher janasya bahudhāpyekaṁ samārāadhanam | 4 | |
Mālavikāgnimitraṁ (Act 1, verse 4)*

Meaning: The sages consider this (drama) to be a visual offering to the gods, which is pleasant to the eye. Rudra (Śhiva — the lord of the arts) divided his body into two, joined with Umā (to form *Ardhanārīśhvara*, representing all human characters). Drama represents various emotions and behaviours of the people of the world produced by the three guṇas (*Sattva, Rajas, Tamas*). It is a single form of entertainment that caters to the diverse tastes of all people.



Performing rituals while singing

Note to the Teacher

The chapters in Theatre are designed to nurture creative thinking. Theatre thrives on exploration, interpretation, and imagination rather than a search for correct or incorrect answers. There is rarely a single ‘right’ way to perform a scene or express an idea. Instead, students are encouraged to experiment, question, interpret, and discover their own unique responses. As teachers, your role is not to evaluate creativity through rigid parameters, but to create a safe and encouraging environment where students feel free to try, fail, improvise, and grow.

This book also intends to guide students towards discovering a **vision and purpose for theatre**. Beyond performance skills, it encourages them to see theatre as a meaningful medium to express ideas, reflect on society, and contribute responsibly. Through creative engagement, students can learn to voice concerns, celebrate strengths, build empathy, and participate thoughtfully in their communities. Thus, theatre becomes not only an art form, but a pathway to becoming aware and responsible citizens.

Teaching **theatre does not require expensive infrastructure** or elaborate equipment. An empty classroom is more than enough. A cleared space can transform into a forest, a courtroom, a battlefield, or a future city through imagination alone. School corridors can become processional pathways; playgrounds can host ensemble performances; the quadrangle can serve as an open-air stage. When students learn to see performance possibilities in everyday spaces, they develop adaptability and innovation.

At the Grade 9 level, students are capable of understanding depth, symbolism, and layered storytelling. Wherever possible, consider inviting experts—actors, directors, designers—or arranging visits to professional theatre spaces. Such **exposure to professional environments** will help them appreciate the craft more deeply.

Most importantly, remember that each child brings a different strength to the theatre space. Some may excel in acting, others in writing, designing, organising, or observing. Not every student needs to shine in every aspect. Help them **identify their individual skills** and encourage meaningful contribution. Theatre is collaborative—and every role matters.

Learning Outcomes That Can Be Assessed		
Curricular Goals	Competencies	Learning Outcomes
Chapter 2: The Stage Is Yours		
1	C1.1, C1.2	Discuss the ideas and process that interest them in dramatic arts Explore the potential of theatre for a social purpose. Demonstrate empathy and sensitivity in interacting with people Interact with peers, teachers, family members, and artists in their community to know more about the scope of theatre
Chapter 3: Symbols and Metaphors on Stage		
2, 3, 4	C4.1 C3.2 C2.1	Understand abstract representation on stage. Build simple metaphors and symbol for story concepts. Consider multiple viewpoints and interpretations in dramatic arts. Present non-judgemental and contextual views with an awareness of geography and cultural diversity. Identify differences in approaches and techniques of scene work at each step of process. For example, explain how the arrangement of various elements convey different meanings and emotions.
Chapter 4: Creativity in Light and Sound		
2, 3	C3.1 C2.1	Understand and apply concepts of light, lenses, electricity, and sound in theatre. Able to blend the science concepts to enhance the creative output on stage. Identify differences in approaches and techniques of scene work at each step of process. For example, explain how the arrangement of various elements convey different meanings and emotions.
Chapter 5: From Vision to Performance: Direction and Acting		
2	C2.2	Experiment with themes and ways of presentation during large collaborative projects targeted towards creating drama. Demonstrate confidence in application of direction concepts to stories and scenes Explore one's own abilities in performance as an individual and in groups
Project: Workshop		
3	C3.1	Experiment with theatre games, skill building activities, and rehearsal techniques Demonstrate familiarity with the proper use and maintenance of costumes, props, and stage equipment used for drama

A Journal of My Theatre Journey

Journalling is a powerful habit in theatre. Every rehearsal, performance, mistake, and breakthrough carries lessons that may be forgotten unless they are reflected upon.



Key points to include in your journal

Though your journal is a free space for you to express, here is a list of points that will help you put down your thoughts. Here is a sample:

12 August – Improvisation Exercise:
“At the Bus Stop” (Group Scene)

What We Did:

Worked in groups of five to create a scene where strangers wait at a bus stop. We had to communicate emotions only through body language and expressions.

I played a nervous student. I was checking my watch repeatedly and tapping my foot to show anxiety.

What I Learned

I realised that small actions can communicate emotions without words. I understood how important it is to observe other actors. When one of us changed the approach, the whole scene changed!

What Challenged Me

I wanted to make my anxiety very obvious, but the teacher asked me to reduce my movements and try smaller gestures. That was uncomfortable but may be it helped the scene feel more natural.

Feedback I Received

- ◆ Good use of body language
- ◆ Need to slow down movements
- ◆ Maintain stronger focus on co-actors instead of the audience

One Memorable Moment

One actor pretended to drop their bag, and everyone reacted without planning. That spontaneous moment felt very real and exciting.

Dos	Don'ts
Write honestly about your feelings and struggles, not what the teacher wants to hear.	Don't copy others' reflections. Every theatre journey is unique.
Be consistent: Write regularly. Small entries are better than long last-minute writing.	Focus on personal learning and insights. Avoid generic lines like 'it was nice', 'it was good'.
Reflect deeply: Go beyond 'what happened'. Write why it mattered to you.	Don't skip difficult experiences. Challenges are usually the biggest learning moments.
Respect privacy: Share respectfully about classmates without mocking or judging.	Don't treat it as a homework task — treat it as a personal artistic record.

2 The Stage Is Yours



Hāsyā Rasa

Welcome back to the world of theatre, where you can bring your imagination to life for many to experience. Be it in a classroom, a terrace, a corridor, a garden or a stage, theatre allows you to tell stories you care about to the people around you. Theatre is a collaborative process where all these roles come together.

As a theatre artist you can be —



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Fig. 2.1. Different roles in theatre



Revisiting the Basics with Vidūṣhaka

Remember **Vidūṣhaka**, the clever, witty companion from classical Indian theatre who always added laughter and insight to every activity? Let us revisit what we have learnt about theatre till now.

Let's revise the key skills you explored with Vidūṣhaka:

- ◆ **Body language:** How you stand, move, and use gestures tells the audience who you are — even before you speak!
- ◆ **Expression and voice:** Your tone, volume, and facial expressions convey emotion and intent.
- ◆ **Improvisation:** Thinking and reimagining! Theatre often surprises you — and improvisation helps you adapt quickly and stay in character.



Fig. 2.2. Vidūṣhaka

- ◆ **Story building:** Every scene, even a small one, needs a beginning, middle, and end. You learned how to shape stories with structure, imagination, and teamwork.

Let us recall

You have studied about the *Nāṭyaśāstra* in Chapter 1 Introduction to the History of Arts. You may also be familiar with the **navarasa**, the nine emotions, which you have learnt about in previous grades. The nine emotions are *śṛṅgāra*, *vīra*, *karuṇa*, *raudra*, *bhayānaka*, *bībhatsa*, *hāsyā*, *adbhuta*, and *śhānta*.



Fig. 2.3. Navarasa



Form Your Theatre Team

Every theatre group has its unique energy and identity. Let your team also have a similar trait. You will name your team, design its logo, define a purpose and create a short performance. These will help you understand how to work together, express your ideas, and bring your collective imagination to create a strong, creative team.

With the help of your teacher, form teams of six to eight members.



Note to the teacher: Assist students in forming teams that are inclusive. You may adjust the size of the teams based on the unique requirements of your classrooms.

Name your team

The name you give should represent ideas or expressions that are meaningful to each team member. Are you a team full of

energy and humour? Or thoughtful and poetic? Strong and bold? Calm and expressive? Discuss what you all share in common and accordingly find a suitable word or phrase as your team's name.

Design a logo

A logo is more than just a picture. Just like a costume on stage informs the audience, at a glance, about a character, who a character is, even before they speak, your logo also could communicate your team's identity.

Begin by examining a few logos around you. For example, the NCERT logo in this book, or look at the logo of your school. What are the things you notice in the logo? What do you think they represent?

Discuss the following prompts as you design your logo:

- ◆ What does theatre mean to you?
- ◆ What do you believe in?
- ◆ What is your team about?
- ◆ What kind of stories do you want to tell?
- ◆ What do you want your audience to experience?



Fig. 2.4.
NCERT logo

Activity 2.1

Logo artwork

Create your team's logo by making a few sketches. Keep your design simple so that it can be easily replicated. Select colours for your logo such that they enhance the ideas you wish to communicate.



Create the final artwork of your logo. Your team's name can be a part of the logo or be placed alongside.



Finding Your Story

One day, a group of theatre students gathered to decide their next play. "Let's do a comedy... maybe from the *Purāṇas*?" they suggested. "No, something with suspense and mystery," said another. Their teacher smiled and asked, "Before you decide the story... tell me — who are you telling it to?" The room fell silent. That day, they learnt their first lesson in doing theatre with a purpose.

Theatre can be a medium to build empathy, raise awareness, and initiate meaningful conversations. As Theatre students, you can create performances that reflect the realities, emotions, and concerns of society. When we create with purpose, our art becomes relevant, impactful, and transformative — for the audience and ourselves.

Discussion circle

Discuss in your team: What should our performance be about?

Write down the responses. Instead of asking, ‘What story do I want to tell?’ you can ask:

- ◆ What stories of resilience and courage deserve to be celebrated?
- ◆ Which traditions bring joy and identity to our people?
- ◆ What dreams inspire the younger generation?
- ◆ What kind of loneliness do elderly people experience?
- ◆ What pressures do students face today?

The aim is not to judge — but to understand. In order to tell a story that connects to people, you extend some of these questions to the people around you, to understand different points of view, we reach out through various means.

Genre

It refers to the categories based on forms and styles of theatre. Tragedy, comedy, fantasy, and musical theatre are some well-known genres of theatre.

Discussion circle

What genre of plays would your team want to perform? Can your team mix genres? Imagine a comic tragedy or a mythical mystery! Make a note of this for your team’s performance.

Forms of theatre

India has many traditions of theatre practised in every region. A few are mentioned in Chapter 1 Introduction to the History of Arts. You can take inspiration from these forms as you transform your stories into a theatre production.

Puppetry

It reminds us that storytelling can live in objects too! A simple handkerchief can become a bird; a stick can become a king. India has a diverse range of puppetry traditions including string puppetry, shadow puppetry, stick/rod puppetry, glove puppetry, and so on.



Fig. 2.5. Kathputli, traditional puppetry of Rajasthan

Let us recall

Refer to Chapter 19 of the Grade 6 Art Education textbook *Kriti*.

Activity 2.2

Make a small puppet from recycled materials. Create a two-minute long performance using the puppet.

Mime

This is a form of theatre where stories are told without the words, speech or dialogue, only through body movements, gestures, and expressions.

Let us recall

Refer to Chapter 2 of the Grade 7 Art Education textbook *Kriti*.

Activity 2.3

Mime a Team Goal

Perform an action that represents what you want to achieve through your team, without speaking. Can your friends guess it?



Fig. 2.6. Young mime artists

Process of making purposeful theatre

Step 1: Define your focus

Each group chooses one social theme based on discussion. For example:

- ❖ What role do festivals play in building community bonds?
- ❖ What makes young people feel hopeful today?

Think of topics that are most relevant to you and the people around you. This becomes your project focus.

Step 2: Framing questions

Asking the right question is key! How you frame the question depends on the kind of tool you use and the person who is answering. You must prepare a set of questions, which can be of two types:

1. Open-ended questions allow people to speak freely in their own words. They encourage storytelling, memories, opinions, personal struggles, and experiences that may not be visible on the surface. Example: Can you share a situation where you felt misunderstood?
2. Close-ended questions offer limited, fixed options such as Yes/ No or multiple choices. They help collect clear, measurable information that can be easily counted and compared. Example: Does your community celebrate festivals that include theatre or folk performances? Yes/ No.

Using both types of questions gives you a holistic picture.



Note to the teacher: Encourage each team to frame two open-ended questions and two close-ended questions.

Step 3: Meet people and gather information

When you meet people, you will need to practise active listening and keen observation.

You can use the following methods to learn more about the people around you.

1. **Questionnaires and surveys:** Useful for collecting perspectives from a larger group
2. **Interviews:** Conversations that allow emotional depth and honest sharing. This can be chosen for a small group of people, especially dignitaries or experts.
3. **Observation:** Watching and recording behaviour in everyday life — in markets, schools, workplaces.

During interactions, make notes and character sketches in your Theatre journal to capture what was said by the people you met. Mention details

such as their age-group, gender, profession, their manner of speaking, as well as their gestures and expressions. All this can help you understand different perspectives and incorporate them into your performance.

Step 4: Turning information into stories for theatre

After collecting responses, gather as a group. Examine the responses through the following questions:

- ◆ What emotions and themes emerged from the interaction?
- ◆ What surprised you?
- ◆ How can the information help you write a story on this topic?

Step 5: Building the story

Choose three key moments of the story. These could combine two or three ideas. Create a situation for each of the key moments. You can use improvisation to help you further develop your characters and script.

Discussion circle

What emotion do you want your audience to feel when they see your work?

Let us recall

Refer to Chapter 2 of the Grade 8 Art Education textbook *Kriti* to recall the different types of scripts, dramatic structures, and genres.

The following points will help you in writing your script:

- ◆ What genres and forms will your team use? For example, will your performance be a puppetry show of a tragedy?
- ◆ Which stage props, costumes, and character make-up will help you tell your story best? How can you best use the resources around you?
- ◆ How will your team assign backstage responsibilities?

Discussion circle

In putting together a theatre production, which role interests you the most?

Step 6: Theatre team production

Now that you have your story's characters and the basic script, prepare to perform the story on stage.

Discussion circle

1. What do you think is the biggest obstacle in forming a theatre team? How can you overcome it?
2. Reflect on your experience of building a story and performing it. Which role did you play and in what ways did your work contribute to the team?
3. Are you familiar with any theatre practitioners or teams? Explore the theatre professionals who perform in your region.

EXERCISES

- Q1. Given below are some themes and activities. Choose each theme and complete all three activities for it. You may add a context, situation, or story to it, wherever required.

Themes

- Hard work leads to success.
- Being kind and helpful to those in trouble is always appreciated.

Activities

- i. Show an action to represent the theme using body language.
 - ii. Speak five lines about the theme with proper voice and expression.
 - iii. Write a short story based on the theme, keeping in mind the beginning–middle–end structure.
- Q2. Match the *rasas* with the expressions.

<i>Raudra</i>	<i>Bhayānaka</i>	<i>Vīra</i>	<i>Karuṇa</i>	<i>Adbhuta</i>
				

- Q3. You are planning to conduct a theatre workshop in your locality. Prepare a questionnaire to collect information on what people are expecting from the workshop.
- Q4. Name the nine *rasas* in the Indian Performing Arts and perform each with either an action or a suitable line of speech.
- Q5. Which qualities would you associate with this image? Give reasons for your answer.

Window

- i. Openness, new perspectives, and curiosity
- ii. Isolation and restriction
- iii. Discipline and strict boundaries
- iv. Confusion and unpredictability



Fig. 2.7. Window